LADAKH: A WARNING FOR THE BJP PG 7

UPFRONT

PUNJAB: TROUBLE FOR MANN PG 8



FOLLOW THE LEADER Abhishek Banerjee (with placard) leads the protest march to Raj Bhawan in Kolkata, Oct. 5

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

WEST BENGAL

ABHISHEK'S DAY OUT

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

It was a national debut of sorts for an emerging regional face, even if it amounted to nothing much more than a few hours of television-friendly drama at Rajghat that ended in a bout of jousting with the beefy gendarmes of Delhi Police and the obligatory detention afterwards. The Trinamool Congress (TMC) had a major grouse against the Centre—the Narendra Modi government, it said, had unfairly frozen West Bengal's share of funds under key central schemes. Hounded back home by the central agencies on a string of corruption cases, it had decided to take the battle of wits to the national stage. And it chose as its protagonist none other than Abhishek Banerjee, the 35-year-old nephew of West Bengal CM and TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee, the party's national general secretary and indeed one of the personages in the crosshairs of the agencies. Originally, Mamata was to lead the two-day protests in Delhi herself, but doctors had prescribed her rest for an old leg injury. So, as she kept an obser-